

scoring almost at a run a ball, sweeping spinners, even stepping out to loft them over the infield.

One such moment came in February 2022, at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad. Mumbai was playing Saurashtra, Rahane squaring off against Pujara, both men under the selectors' gaze with a Test series against Sri Lanka looming.

Neither would make the cut. A day after his omission, Pujara answered with an 83-ball 91, laced with 16 fours and a six. He had been dismissed for a duck in the first innings, but his reply was a statement of defiance. Mumbai packed the close-in field; the ball was turning sharply, yet Pujara kept striding down the pitch. At one point, he danced out to off-spinner Tanush Kotian and lofted him, almost casually, over long-on. **For a batter supposedly past his prime, there was nothing hesitant — only the old certainty of a man who still believed time was on his side.**

His appetite for runs remained immense till the end. Across First-Class cricket — Tests, Ranji Trophy games, and county seasons — he faced 41,715 deliveries, an astonishing testament to stamina and stubbornness. Out of them, he carved 66 hundreds, many of them monumental in scale. His tally of double centuries places him fourth on the all-time list, behind only Don Bradman, Wally Hammond, and Patsy Hendren. Such company underlines what Pujara truly was: not merely a man who occupied the crease, but one who turned occupation into dominion, transforming hours into monuments of concentration.

At Brisbane in 2021, Pujara became less batter than barricade. Cummins and Hazlewood tested him with a storm of short balls, blows landing on helmet, ribs and fingers. One delivery reared awkwardly and struck his hand; for once, the pain showed as he winced and crouched for several minutes. Yet, he rose, as he always did, to

resume the fight. India still needed nearly 200, and Pujara summoned a familiar creed — 'over my dead body'. His half-century took 196 balls, the slowest of his career, but every strike absorbed was another thread woven into India's escape. Even when a bouncer knocked the stem guard off his helmet, he carried on, stoic and immovable.

That resilience had deep roots. Discipline was instilled early by his father and first coach, Arvind. As a boy in Rajkot, Pujara was not allowed the indulgences of childhood festivals: no firecrackers at Diwali, no kites at Uttarayan.

"What if you burnt your hand or cut a finger? You cannot miss the nets for such things," Arvind would insist. Years later, at the Gabba, it was those lessons of denial and discipline that echoed in every block and bruise, turning a batter into a bulwark as India chased history.

Pujara was never a creature of the age. When cricket tilted towards the ephemeral, he offered permanence. When speed became the currency, he traded in span. Five ODIs were scattered across his career, little more than anomalies; he belonged wholly to the long form and never pretended otherwise. In an impatient world, he held his ground, and in doing so reminded us of what Test cricket was built upon.

Watching him could test one's own patience. Crowds fidgeted, broadcasters despaired. Yet, those who stayed the course discovered something rare: the drama of attrition, the artistry of survival. Pujara changed not just games, but moods.

He never sought adoration, only the contest itself — man against ball, time against hope.

Now that he has walked away, the crease feels a little barer, the afternoons a little shorter. He leaves no slogans, no postures, only the memory of a batter who made time stand still. In Test cricket's long chronicle, that may be the most enduring monument of all.

Fact file



7,195 TEST RUNS

Eighth Indian to cross 7,000 after Tendulkar, Dravid, Gavaskar, Kohli, Laxman, Sehwag and Ganguly.

103 TESTS

One of only 14 Indians to reach the milestone.

6,529 RUNS AT NO. 3

Second only to Dravid for India; among the global greats at one-drop with Sangakkara, Ponting, Williamson and Amla.

11 WINS IN SENA COUNTRIES

More than any other Indian.

21,301 FIRST-CLASS RUNS WITH 66 CENTURIES

Behind only Gavaskar, Tendulkar and Dravid among Indians.